

AWL AGRI'S NEW BET

THE COMPANY IS TRYING TO DECOUPLE ITSELF FROM SWINGS IN CRUDE OIL PRICES AS THE WEST ASIA CRISIS PUSHES UP COSTS

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PHOTO MONTAGE BY **BANDEEP SINGH**

AWL AGRI BUSINESS Ltd isn't exactly preening these days about its position as India's top edible oil maker. Rather, it is seeking to sell more packaged foods and staples to cut its dependence on oils.

Reason: the maker of the Fortune brand of edible oil and Kohinoor rice is trying to find a shield against frequent price swings in its principal product line, cooking oils, and consumer demand.

Take the latest conflict in West Asia. Crude oil prices have gained 65% since the US and Israel started bombing Iran at the end of February. Prices of cooking oils such as palm, soybean and sunflower oil have risen in response by as much as 20%.

Vegetable oils are diverted for production of biodiesel, an eco-friendly alternative to petroleum diesel, during times of conflict. Supply chain disruptions and panic buying by households drive up costs.

To add to the discomfiture of edible oil makers like AWL Agri Business, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has called on households



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